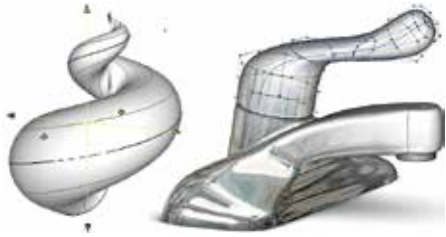


enhance its abilities. It is available as a free download with a restriction that limits file saving to 25 times. It is compatible with a variety of CAD file types, especially those from Autodesk, but in the cases of formats post-2007, Rhino converts them to its own format first. It is the preferred 3D design software used by the Royal College of Arts, London for 3D printing projects.

Solidworks

As 3D printing is finding more industrial and consumer interest, Solidworks has become one of the most successful and profitable CAD softwares. Its relative ease of use and functionality for 3D printing purposes has made it an



One of the most versatile and accurate real world physics CAD programs.

emerging favourite. Solidworks also distinguish itself from other CAD programs due to its aptitude for mechanical 3D projects. It introduces new workflows and features that are more inclined towards functional product design as compared to other programs. Features such as “Design Intent” allow designers to instruct the program on how designs need to function in the real world which ensures that functionality of design isn’t lost or missed in the design process due to the software compensating variables for other changes. Solidworks also comes with a specialty tool called Print3D which allows the designs to be converted to the STL file format.

In addition to the above companies like Adobe have already begun introducing 3D printing functionality to their softwares by partnering up with 3D printer makers in America. The growth of this segment is encouraging many design related software makers to look towards 3D printing as a growth opportunity.

Open Source or Free Softwares

For beginners the following software’s are a great way to get started on understanding 3D CAD design and its usage in 3D printing.

Google SketchUp

SketchUp is an easy to use and learn program from Google that allows users to build models using a basic set of tools. The learning curve is simple